

Enemies at Work

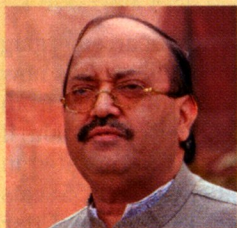
Shrewd politician, ruthless administrator, Mayawati can also be vindictive. A list of her pet hates.



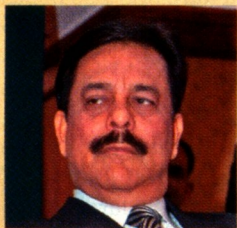
MULAYAM SINGH YADAV: For a brief while, he was her ally and the two parties even shared power for a brief while in 1993. But the daggers were drawn after the infamous Lucknow state guest house incident where SP workers kept her locked up for hours.



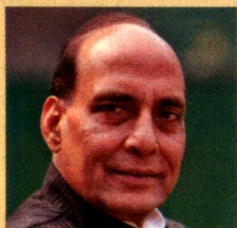
RAM VILAS PASWAN: He had a head-start over Mayawati who was just out of Delhi's Kalindi College when Paswan won the 1977 Lok Sabha election. While he was content remaining minister, Mayawati worked the crowds and built a formidable party organisation.



AMAR SINGH: Mayawati thinks he is the inspiration behind many of Mulayam's offensives against her. During the cash-for-vote sting, he produced an MP who said Mayawati had offered him Rs 30 crore to switch sides. Firmly believes that the UPA will pay for cosying up to him.



SUBRATA ROY SAHARA: India's most mysterious businessman thought his cross-party friendships lent him invincibility. His closeness with Mulayam and Amar was enough to make him her special target. She ordered the bulldozers into the imposing Sahara City in Lucknow.



RAJNATH SINGH: For the BJP chief, the sight of Mayawati is akin to a red rag to a bull. He seethes. He took umbrage when she threw fellow Rajput and alleged don Raja Bhaiya into jail. Dalit diva she may be, but this Rajput has nothing but contempt for her.

SHIV VISHWANATHAN
Social scientist

“The idea of a Dalit becoming PM might make Delhi more cosmopolitan as it means politics is not a club. She understands the importance of election strategy.”

Congress's refusal to give Ramdas Athawale, a Dalit leader, a cabinet berth. After all, it was Maharashtra that gave birth to the Dalit movement and Ambedkar's Republican Party. She is thinking big, as big as India, and choosing friends—well, for the time being at least—accordingly.

Only Mayawati can undo Mayawati, the story of every autocrat. She may have undergone a remarkable makeover, in looks and attitude: less shrill, more accessible, media-friendly, and not averse to flaunting her wealth. She is India's highest taxpayer among politicians, with real estate in the toniest part of Delhi. By CBI estimates, she is worth Rs 52 crore. Mayawati does not think that you have to remain poor to serve the poor. The source of her income, she says, is the benevolence of her admirers. Millionaire Mayawati is a proud symbol of Dalit enterprise—that is how the cult of Maya is marketed by her image makers. And, going by trends, “corruption” cannot defeat you in an election. Hubris can.

In politics, it is the winnability factor which serves as glue for disparate groupings to stay together. Mayawati knows that, as do her political allies. She is aware that Uttar Pradesh has provided eight of the 13 prime ministers since Independence, reinforcing the political adage that whoever rules Uttar Pradesh rules India. Seven were Brahmins, one Jat, two Thakurs and one Sikh. Maya genuinely feels that the time has come for a Dalit prime minister. Ever since V.P. Singh was thrown out of power by an agitation against his Mandal politics, the forces who were humbled have been gaining clout and ground. The south was already controlled by backward class leaders and in recent years, backward caste leaders have been taking centre stage—Mulayam Singh, Lalu Prasad and Ram Vilas Paswan, who play an important role at the Centre.

What emboldens Mayawati is that neither the Congress nor the BJP have a backward leader they can project as an alternative to her. It was because of Mayawati's growing political stature that Mulayam, Lalu and Paswan came together on the same platform last week to project an alternative to the Congress and the BJP. Mayawati may lack a coherent agenda on foreign policy, defence or national economic issues but, in the emerging political vacuum, that may not prove enough to stop her from dreaming of a bronze statue rising over Raisina Hill.

with Subhash Mishra in Lucknow